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Artist's Impression



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How about a *‘flying visit’* to Pondicherry?

A mound of concrete housing a manhole is in the middle of Pondicherry Salai in Sholinganallur; motorists, particularly motorcyclists, should watch out

PRINCE FREDERICK

There are old roads whose star is ever on the ascendant. There are old roads that reluctantly make peace with the disconcerting but real idea that they have to coexist and share the spotlight with new-fangled funky Millennial roads that shot into prominence only the other night. And there are old roads that rest on their laurels, retaining names that hint at these glorious past. And in every other aspect, these roads are painfully lacklustre.

In the third category is Pondicherry Salai (also called Pondicherry Pattai Road) in the Sholinganallur-Semmancherry area. It runs parallel to the mighty OMR and gives up the jog, panting furiously, just seconds into it. Long-time residents would note that the road, now narrower than a sub-miniature camera film, once stretched all the way to Pondicherry. The contrast between legend and reality is not only striking but glaring: the road going under the grand name Pondicherry Pattai Road now is hardly long by any de-



The manhole at Pondicherry Salai in Sholinganallur
PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

finition of lengthy roadways, loses its identity quickly in a maze of interior roads.

An ‘unusual revival’

But there is a rather unusual, probably even path-breaking effort to make good this road’s continuing claim today: that it would take its “beneficiaries” all the way to Pondicherry. This effort is signified by a massively elevated and widely spread concrete bump housing a manhole. Given its position on the

road, it appears to be a manhole that is part of an underlying sewage system. This bump is located at the point of Pondicherry Salai where it meets TNHB A Road (also called TNHB Main Road). In rough navigational terms, this is a short section of Pondicherry Salai lying on what is the northern side of TNHB A Road. Much of Pondicherry Salai lies on the southern side of TNHB A Road.

This mound of concrete housing the manhole is high and wide

and motorists entering Pondicherry Salai or exiting it to move into TNHB A Road cannot skirt around it. It might come across as a boil in an inconvenient part of the human body, one that cannot be ignored. There is an upside to every painful aspect of human existence. This bump is so high it can launch a motorcyclist bumping into it at full pelt all the way to Pondicherry, in a “ticket-less flight”. A flying visit to Pondicherry, if you like.

Solar kiosk by OMR college student wins laurels



Rithika S. K., a third-year student at KCG College of Technology, has been awarded an IET India scholarship for HEKIO, a solar-powered medical kiosk designed to make basic health screenings possible in underprivileged areas. This project is aimed to solve the problem of late detection and inaccessible primary health screening, especially in crowded public spaces and semi-urban areas where people do not regularly visit hospitals for preventive check-ups.

Rithika observed how most people seek medical help only after symptoms become serious, even for conditions that could have been detected earlier through simple screening.

HEKIO is a user-friendly self-sustaining health care kiosk that can perform simple but critical health tests without adequate medical services, said a release.

The IET India Scholarship Award, a flagship initiative of the Institution of Engineering and Technology (IET) is in its 10th edition and is recognised as one of India’s most prestigious award programmes for student engineers, added the release. The award carries a scholarship prize of ₹10 lakh.

Pen show in Adyar from March 6

The third edition of ‘Chennai Pen Show 2026’ will be held from March 6 to 8, 2026, at Fika, Adyar. The event will offer an unmatched range of fountain pens, inks, stationery, and rare vintage writing instruments. Writing enthusiasts, collectors, and brands from across the world will be taking part in the three-day celebration of the art of writing. Last year’s event drew more than 16,000 attendees, said a release.

The key highlight this year will be the ‘Chennai Pen Show Select’, a dedicated space showcasing a handpicked collection of brands and retailers. FIKA is at Adyar (Behind Malar Hospital), No.13, Second Main Road, Gandhi Nagar, Adyar.

Entry is free. For details, visit www.chennaipenshow.com

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RESIDENTS ON 'NIGHT DUTY'

Thuvakkam relaunched 'Clean Up After Dark' with a drive on February 28 at an old age home in Perungudi **P2**



INFECTIOUS ENERGY

Bhuvana Raj from Thalambur and Saravanan Palanichami from Kovilambakkam philosophy of sustainable energy use in their home settings is rubbing off on neighbours and friends **P4**

Gated communities present key concerns

Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations organises a meeting with representatives of political parties



FORRRA office bearers submitting a memorandum to AIADMK leader K. P. Kandan along with other residents. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations (FORRRA), representing 15 gated communities and several thousand families along Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam Radial Road, has submitted a memorandum of issues to senior AIADMK leader and Chennai Suburban District Secretary K. P. Kandan, in view of the upcoming elections.

Over 50 residents representing multiple apartment communities along Radial Road participated in the meeting held in one of the gated communities and voiced views on infrastructure challenges, safety concerns and other pressing matters impacting daily life with Kandhan, said a release.

The AIADMK leader heard all the concerns that were presented

and assured the residents that appropriate action would be initiated to address them in a time-bound manner. S. Viswanathan, AIADMK's St Thomas Mount North Union Secretary, also took part in the meeting with residents.

Office-bearers of FORRRA also met Sholinganallur MLA S. Aravind Ramesh and presented their memorandum of issues at an event organised under the leadership of MP S. Jagathrakshakan in Neelankarai.

The comprehensive memorandum prepared by FORRRA outlined several civic concerns affecting residents and sought commitments for their resolution in a time-bound manner. Home to thousands of working professionals, senior citizens and school children, the arterial road has witnessed rapid residential growth without commensurate infrastructure development in the last few years.

FORRRA in a press release stated the initiative was undertaken ahead of the upcoming Assembly election in the larger interest of the entire Radial Road community, with the objective of ensuring coordinated efforts towards long-term solutions and improved civic amenities for all residents.

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Residents on ‘night duty’

Thuvakkam relaunched ‘Clean Up After Dark’ with a drive on February 28 at an old age home in Perungudi

LIFFY THOMAS

Chennai-based non-profit Thuvakkam has relaunched its signature initiative ‘Clean Up After Dark’. It returned in a refreshed form on February 28 at Anbusolai old age home in Perungudi.

The essence of this drive: resident-volunteers taking to the streets after evenfall, typically after 6 p.m. and making them squeaky clean, the work continuing till the wee hours of the following day.

Thuvakkam ran ‘Clean Up After Dark’ for close to four years until the pandemic forced it into an extended hibernation. In the pre-pandemic years, the clean-up happened at public spaces including government schools, busy roads and markets, many a time twice a month.

In the Mylapore area, volunteers spruced up bus shelters in Mandaveli, Luz Corner and St Mary’s Road by removing posters, clearing the cobwebs

and giving them a fresh coat of paint.

Krishna Kumar Suresh, founder, Thuvakkam, reveals the campaign got this young NGO popular and brought many new volunteers into its fold.

They would combine it with events such as Dhan Utsav to draw volunteers from organisations or neighbourhoods.

In many localities, residents suggested places that needed a clean-up.

“We had painted a government school in KK Nagar, leaving to complete with artworks. The paint has now worn off a bit, not the message,” says Krishna.

The relaunched version of this initiative will follow the same pattern. The plan is to take up one activity a month.

Clean-up as such does not require any special skills but just the willingness to listen to the instructions and carry them out on the field during the activity.

Thuvakkam invites resident associations and institutions to suggest places in their locality that needs a clean-up.

For more details, call Dinesh Babu at 97915 19208



Volunteers paint the walls of Valluvar Kottam at a drive organised by Nippon Paint and Thuvakkam in 2017.



A mixed party of migratory ducks at the salterns in Nemmeli

▼ If one looked at the ducks swimming in the waters in the picture above, they would realise what the hazy mass of colours on the bund represent: Eurasian wigeon, Garganey and Northern shoveler. In the picture below, the Northern shoveler and the Eurasian wigeon are in huge numbers, and the former is the foreground and seems to be in bold relief. A glimpse of a mixed party of migratory ducks at the salterns off the Nemmeli-Thirupurur Link Road (connecting East Coast Road and Old Mahabalipuram Road) on February 22, 2026.

PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK



Painting equity and unity

SRM marks Zero Discrimination Day with art competition at Ekkattuthangal; the first, second and third prizes were secured by students from Anna University, Madras Christian College and Sri Annai Kamakshi Music and Fine Arts College respectively

The Department of Visual Communication and Faculty of Science and Humanities at SRM Institute of Science and Technology – Vadapalani Campus organised an inter-collegiate painting competition titled HUES 2026 at the Ekkattuthangal campus on February 27 to commemorate Zero Discrimination Day, observed every year on March 1.

According to a press release, the competition was centered on the theme “Democracy Begins with



Winners of the competition.

Participation,” encouraging young artists to express ideas of equality, inclusivity, and active civic engagement through art. Twenty-one colleges from in and around Chennai enthusiastically participated, show-

casing remarkable creativity and originality, the release adds.

The programme was graced by R. Sasikala, Assistant Director (Design), Weavers Service Centre, Ministry of Textiles, Government of India, as chief guest. With her address, she inspired students to integrate innovation with cultural sensitivity. The entries were judged by eminent artist Alagarraja based on parameters such as originality, creativity, composition, color harmony and relevance to the theme.

The first, second and third prizes were secured by students from Anna University, Madras Christian College and Sri Annai Kamakshi Music and Fine Arts College respectively. HUES 2026 stood as a vibrant celebration of artistic excellence and a meaningful tribute to democratic values and zero discrimination.

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One-minute video contest for students

The Public Relations Society of India (PRSI), Chennai Chapter, in association with Coromandel International Limited, invites nominations for a state-level One-Minute Public Service Announcement (PSA) Video Contest on the theme “Save Food, Save Future.”

The contest aims to inspire young filmmakers to use visual storytelling to promote food conservation and highlight the value of every grain produced through farmers’ hard work. Open to college students, this initiative encourages youth participation in spreading awareness about responsible consumption and sustainability through impactful short-format cinema, said a press release.

The contest will focus on the theme “Save Food, Save Future” and the video must be produced in Tamil with a duration of exactly one minute. The last date for submission is April 14, 2026.

Winners will be awarded attractive cash prizes, with ₹25,000 for the first prize, ₹15,000 for the second prize, and ₹10,000 for the third prize.

The competition is open to college students between the ages of 17 and 24 who are studying in Tamil Nadu or Puducherry.

Participants must submit strictly original content, and any copied or adapted material from YouTube or other platforms will lead to disqualification. All entries must strictly adhere to the exact one-minute duration requirement.

Entries will be evaluated by a panel of experts based on script and storytelling, direction, cinematography, production quality, and background music. For further details, please contact N. Raja, Secretary, Public Relations Society of India - Chennai Chapter, Mobile: 63838 53001

On the theme “Save Food, Save Future”, the video must be produced in Tamil with a duration of exactly one minute

Gaura Poornima events at ISKCON on March 3

The International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) will celebrate ‘Gaura Poornima’ on March 3 at Akkarai-Sholingallur.

The festivity will begin at 4.30 a.m. with Mangala Arati and Japa, at 7 a.m., Guru Puja, 8 a.m., Darshan Arati, and 8:30 p.m., ‘Abhishekam’ and ‘Arati’. For details, contact R. Subramanian at 98400 76024.

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Even as Wels in Austria hosted World Sustainable Energy Days 2026 from February 24 to 27, *The Hindu Downtown* picked the brains of quiet influencers Bhuvana Raj from Thalambur and Saravanan Palanichami from Kovilambakkam whose philosophy of sustainable energy use in their home settings is rubbing off on neighbours and friends

Infectious energy



Saravanan Palanichami and Bhuvana Raj with their respective solar installations. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

There is a pleasant monotony to how Bhuvana Raj's electricity bill reads for most part of the year. For nearly ten months annually, every billing cycle, the needle stays at zero (discounting the small regular fee).

A sustainability practitioner and zero waste consultant, Bhuvana installed a rooftop solar system at her home in Thalambur, off OMR, in 2018, when residential solar adoption in Chennai Metropolitan Area was yet to shine brightly.

Although the initial estimate suggested a 2 kW system would suffice, the family chose to plan ahead. "The estimate given for our house was 2 kW. But we decided to add one more unit, thinking that our consumption would increase in the future and we should be able to offset that as well. So we went in for a 3 kW system in 2018 itself," she says. The system cost about ₹1.5 lakh after subsidy.

"I am not exactly sure when it broke even, but I think it was

around four years after installation," she adds.

Only during peak summer, when air conditioner use increases, does the family pay anything at all. "Only during April and May, when consumption increases because of AC usage, do we pay an amount for consumption." And this amount is still one of ridiculously small numbers.

"Recently, they started charging a network fee of around ₹300 plus, so that is the only regular fee we are paying now," she explains. "Not worrying about electricity bills, especially when others pay ₹10,000 or ₹12,000 during summer, is very reassuring," she says.

Though her overall experience is pleasant, Bhuvana would like to see some wrinkles ironed out, not on her end, but Tangedco's.

"When we generate more energy than we use, it goes back to the grid, but Tangedco does not pay us for that surplus. Besides, there is no dashboard to show how many unused units we are giving back," she says.

She adds that people often have doubts when choosing systems. Off

grid systems use batteries and can function during outages. Systems connected to the grid are more economical but shut down during power cuts for safety reasons. "Our area gets flooded during monsoons, and sometimes power cuts continue for days. In such situations, off grid systems help. But when we did the math, on grid made more sense economically in the long run," she says.

In her gated villa community of around 330 houses, rooftop solar adoption has steadily increased. "Around 30 to 40 per cent have gone solar. We are not actively promoting it, but people are installing it on their own after understanding the benefits" she says.

For Bhuvana, the decision goes beyond savings. "I see solar not just as a cost saving option but also as a responsible choice for the future. In our country, we have abundant sunlight almost throughout the year," she says.

She also believes more attention must be paid to what happens later. "After 20 or 30 years, what happens to these panels? How will they be recycled? These are areas

where more research is needed," she says, adding that policy and research must evolve alongside adoption.

A smart move

A software engineer based in Kovilambakkam, Saravanan Palanichami installed his first solar system 13 years ago, at the time he built his house. "The original idea was to ensure uninterrupted power supply," he says. Instead of depending entirely on an inverter connected to the grid, he chose a 1.4 kilowatt off grid system with batteries that could function like a UPS.

For years, that system powered the essentials – fans, refrigerator, televisions, computers and lights. During the day, solar panels charged the batteries. At night, the stored energy ran the house until early morning. When Cyclone Vardah struck Chennai and power cuts lasted for days, his decision proved wise. "During major storms in Chennai, including Cyclone Vardah, when there were week long power cuts, this system proved extremely useful," he recalls.

But the real turning point came recently, with the purchase of an electric vehicle.

"Recently, we bought an electric vehicle. We realised that if the car had to be truly zero emission, the energy used to charge it should also come from renewable sources," he says. That realisation prompted the installation of an additional 6 kilowatt on grid solar system.

Unlike the battery backed setup, the on grid system operates independently of household wiring. "The on grid system is not connected to any of my appliances, including the EV. It supplies power back to the grid through the power lines," he explains. Through net metering, electricity generated during the day is exported to the grid.

His advice to EV owners: "If you have an on grid system, you are already prepared. Try to charge your EV during the day to maximise the use of your generated power. If you have to charge at night, your solar installation will still reduce your overall electricity cost, but you will not be reducing the load on the grid at that time."

Aqua therapy in Adyar for knee rehab

Shri Physio Rehab (SPR) in Adyar has introduced an international-standard, doctor-supervised Aqua Therapy unit, bringing evidence-based aquatic rehabilitation closer to patients suffering from knee arthritis, shoulder pain, sports injuries, and mobility challenges.

Founded by Dr. Shriram Krishnamoorthy, Orthopaedic Surgeon with over 15 years of experience in knee replacement, sports injuries and arthroscopy, Shri Physio Rehab integrates orthopaedic expertise with structured rehabilitation placing aqua therapy at the heart of conservative treatment before surgical intervention, said a press release.

In a communication, Dr. Shriram says, "Many patients avoid exercise because of pain. Water removes that fear. It supports the body, reduces load on joints, and allows safe strengthening. Our aim is always to try structured rehabilitation before advising surgery."



The Aqua Therapy unit is especially beneficial for knee arthritis patients, ligament and meniscus injuries, post knee replacement rehabilitation, frozen shoulder and rotator cuff issues, sports injuries and geriatric patients with balance issues, the press release adds.

Aqua Therapy sessions are

priced at ₹1499 per session (with exclusive trainer supervision).

Centre timings: Monday-Saturday: 9 a.m. - 9 p.m.; Sunday: 9 a.m. - 4 p.m.

Appointments: 044 45055509 / 99529 00206

Location: 14/31, 3rd Avenue, Indira Nagar, Adyar.

Fish bin for plastic waste set up at Thiruvannmiyur beach



As part of a corporate social responsibility initiative, Inchcape has set up a fish-shaped dustbin at Thiruvannmiyur beach. According to a press release, the project was implemented with the support of the Greater Chennai Corporation - South and communiTREE, an organisation focused on environment conservation. Rajini Ravi, Global Head of Finance Operations, Inchcape; Hafiz Khan of communiTREE; employees and volunteers took part in the installation event. The steel bin is 10 feet in height and six feet in width. By virtue of its design, the bin is expected to spread awareness about the ill effects of plastic on marine ecosystems.

Inter-school sports events mark golden jubilee celebrations



P.S. Senior Secondary School conducted a series of inter-school sporting events in January 2026, celebrating talent, teamwork and sportsmanship.

The Shri P.C. Sekhar Memorial U-14 boys Cricket Tournament, held under the guidance of TNCA since 2000, was conducted at St. Bede's Ground with 16 leading schools participation. Ramachandra Public School won the title, and Sri Sankara Adyar were runners-up.

The 3rd C.V. Narasimhan Inter-School Futsal Tournament (U-18 boys & girls) saw 16 boys' teams and 8 girls' teams compete at PS Senior Secondary School ground; P.S. Senior won the boys' title, while Hindu

Senior Secondary School, Adyar won the girls' category. Chinmaya Vidyalaya, Anna Nagar, and P.S. Senior were runners-up.

The P.S. Golden Jubilee Under -14 boys and girls Basketball Tournament was held on January 21 and 22 with 10 boys teams and 10 girls teams participating. P.S. Senior won both boys' and girls' titles, and Chettinad Vidyashram and Vidya Mandir as runners-up.

The Golden Jubilee Kiddies Athletic Meet welcomed 385 participants from 16 schools. P.S. Senior and PSBB KK Nagar won the boys' and girls' championships; RMK Thiruverkadu and DAV Mogappair were runners-up.

Remembering Subramania Bharati

Shriram Bharathi Kalai Ilakkiya Kazhagam recently observed the 144th birth anniversary of freedom fighter and poet Subramania Bharathi at Krishna Gana Sabha, T. Nagar. Three eminent scholars promoting Bharathi's work across the globe, M. Thyagarajan, Kalaimamani Keezhambur Sankara Subramanian, and V.G. Booma, were felicitated on the occasion with cash awards and citations.

Ku. Gnanasambanthan, emeritus, professor Thiagarajar College, Madurai, spoke on 'Vetri Mael Vetri'.

Justice R. Suresh Kumar, Madras High Court, released a book, 'Avvaiyin Senthaimizh Puthaiyal.'

A copy of the book was distributed to all attendees of the event.

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It was raining drones

Students showcased their prowess at the national-level drone challenge organised by KCG College of Technology



During the event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Eighty-five teams from across the country showcased advanced unmanned aerial systems at the Drone Development Challenge (DDC) 2026 hosted by KCG College of Technology.

Organised by the Society of Automotive Engineers India - Southern Section (SAEISS) and the Department of Aeronautical and Aerospace Engineering, the na-

tional-level competition brought together engineering students to design, fabricate, and demonstrate fully functional drones.

The challenge followed a rigorous three-stage evaluation model designed to mirror real-world aerospace assessment frameworks, said a release.

On day 1, participating teams submitted detailed technical design reports covering aerodynamic calcula-

tions, propulsion architecture, structural configuration, and mission strategy before an expert panel. This was followed by a thorough physical inspection of the drone systems to verify build quality, compliance, and engineering accuracy.

On days 2 and 3, teams conducted live flight demonstrations, testing drones under monitored conditions for endurance, maneuverability, stability, payload handling, and mission completion accuracy. The structured evaluation ensured that students were assessed not only on design concepts but also on execution, reliability, and operational performance.

A release stated that the challenge was designed to simulate industry-standard validation processes, preparing students for careers in aerospace manufacturing, drone services, and defence technology. The farewell ceremony recognised the winners for their exceptional technical innovation.



Job fair held at college

Annai Velankanni's College of Arts & Science along with Magic Bus India Foundation organised a job fair at the college campus. According to a press release close to 50 reputed companies

took part.

Around 800 students, both under-graduation and post-graduation from various colleges, attended the fair and close to 500 candidates received appointment order, adds the release.



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Assistance given to differently abled

Lions International District 3241F distributed groceries to 100 differently-abled persons. According to a press release, a financial assistance of ₹10,000 each was also given to an intellectually-disabled girl and a cerebral palsy affected boy.

Also a sum of ₹500 was distributed to 200-differently abled persons.

The event was held at ECI Matriculation Higher Secondary School, Ekkattuthangal.

On the occasion, Beacon of Hope for the Differ-

ently-Abled Award was presented to Saisankara Panchapakesan, founder, Chennai Sai Thunai Matrimonils in recognition of his service towards the welfare of the differently-abled in Tamil Nadu for more than 30 years.

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